HILCHOT SHABBAT

Should the Rabbi Do the Shopping? Preparing for Shabbat

Given Thursday 12 November 2026 · Hilchot Shabbat | Siman 250-251

Sefer: Shulhan Arukh, Orah Hayim, Hilchot Shabbat **Siman:** 250, seifim 1-2, and 251, seifim 1-2
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Thursday Hilchot Shabbat class, Thursday 11 May 2023

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Seif 1: do something yourself

Siman 250 deals with preparing the Shabbat meals. The Shulhan Arukh: wake up early on Friday to prepare what is needed for Shabbat. Even if you have many servants, try to prepare something yourself, to honour Shabbat.

The Gemara gives examples. Rav Hisda would cut vegetables. Rabbah and Rav Yosef would chop wood for the fire. Rav Nahman would tidy the house, bring in the Shabbat vessels and take out the weekday ones. Everyone should learn from them and not say "it is beneath someone like me". On the contrary: "This is your kavod."

Why is this not beneath a great rabbi? The Gemara says that a distinguished person who finds a stray donkey need not return it, because of kevod haberiyot, human dignity. Yet elsewhere Rav Nahman insisted on building his own balcony. The Rabbi explained the difference: when it is clearly recognisable in the act itself that you are doing a misvah, the act is your honour. On Friday everyone knows that sweeping the house or chopping wood is for Shabbat. A rabbi leading a donkey down the street could be doing it for any reason, so it is not recognisably a misvah.

The Mishnah Berurah also explains that it is better to do a misvah yourself than through an agent, and the misvah of honouring Shabbat applies to everyone.

Friday morning, or Thursday?

The source is the pasuk about the man: "On the sixth day they shall prepare what they bring in." Just as the man was gathered early in the morning, the preparation should be early, straight after prayers. If you have a regular shiur after prayers, do not cancel it; but if the fish shop will be closed by the time the shiur ends, miss the shiur and buy the fish.

The Mishnah Berurah goes further. If the market is early, you may go shopping before praying, because this is "business of heaven". If necessary you may even pray without a minyan to buy what you need for Shabbat. But you may not let the time for prayer pass.

Shopping on Thursday. The Mishnah Berurah says that in the winter it is better to prepare on Thursday. The Rabbi noted how rare it is for the Mishnah Berurah to go against the plain

Shulhan Arukh, and explained: the Shulhan Arukh was written in Israel, where Shabbat always comes in between about 5.30 and 7.30. The Mishnah Berurah lived in Poland, with short winter days like England. If Shabbat comes in at 3.30, buying meat on Friday morning that needs hours of cooking makes no sense. Today, too, many people work on Friday.

His rule: if you are free on Friday, prepare on Friday. If you work, or it is winter, it is absolutely fine to do it on Thursday or Thursday night.

Something before Shabbat as well. The Mishnah Berurah says one should also do something right before Shabbat, a "double" preparation. A talmid hakham should do something in the morning and something just before Shabbat. The Rabbi said his own jobs are the shopping, the urn and the timers.

Saving the best for Shabbat

The Mishnah Berurah brings the dispute of Shammai and Hillel. Shammai ate all week for Shabbat: if he found a fine animal on Sunday, he kept it for Shabbat; if he found a better one later, he ate the first. Hillel trusted that each day would bring its own good, "Barukh HaShem yom yom". The halacha follows Hillel, but the poskim say that someone who does not have that level of bitahon should do like Shammai.

The Rabbi's practical advice: if you find something special and you can easily buy it again before Shabbat, enjoy it now. If not, keep it for Shabbat. He added that saving something nice for Shabbat, whether a food, a book or a present, gives children a deep appreciation of Shabbat.

More customs of preparation

- **Tasting the food.** The Mishnah Berurah writes that it is a misvah to taste each dish on Friday, to check the seasoning. Anyone may do it; men tend to like this misvah.
- **Teshuvah on Friday.** Just as we wash and put on clean clothes, we prepare spiritually. Judaism has a pattern of reflection at the end of each period: Elul at the end of the year, Yom Kippur Katan at the end of the month (from the Ari and originally a Sefaradi practice, today kept more in Ashkenazi shuls), Friday at the end of the week, and the bedtime prayers at the end of the day.
- **Sharpen the knives.** The Rema says to prepare and sharpen the knives; the Mishnah Berurah explains that a blunt knife can lead to arguments at the table.

Seif 2: plenty of meat and wine. Buy as much meat, wine and delicacies as you can afford. As we learned in siman 242, on Shabbat this means what you enjoy. On Yom Tov one should have meat even if one is not usually a meat eater.

Siman 251: working on Friday afternoon

Seif 1: one who does work on Friday from minhah onwards does not see blessing from it. Which minhah? - The Tur: minhah gedolah, half an hour after midday. - Others: minhah ketanah, two and a half seasonal hours before the end of the day.

The Shulhan Arukh brings both as "some say", and the rule is that the halacha follows the second. So the Mishnah Berurah rules minhah ketanah. In the London summer that may

mean stopping around 5.30 or 6, even if you bring Shabbat in at 9.

"Work" here means regular labour, not specifically the 39 Melakhot. Exceptions: - **Occasional work.** The Rema: doing it on an irregular basis, such as finishing a deal one Friday, is permitted. - **Employees.** This applies to your own work, not to an employee. An employer must give a Jewish employee enough time to get home and do the basic Shabbat preparations (the Gemara's measure is filling a jug of water, cooking a small fish and lighting a candle), taking into account how far he lives. - **Work for Shabbat.** Seif 2: mending your own or a friend's clothes for Shabbat is permitted all day, as is writing books for your own learning, which is a misvah. But not paid work for others. A haircut is permitted all day.

So kosher food shops may stay open until shortly before Shabbat, as they serve Shabbat needs. The Rabbi's example of work that should stop at minhah ketanah is a sofer's shop selling and checking mezuzot and tefillin, which has nothing to do with Shabbat, unless there is an urgent need such as a Sefer Torah needed the next morning.

He also mentioned that one should not hold a big learning programme on Friday, since it is the time to prepare, though he personally found Friday a peaceful day.

Practical summary

- Everyone should personally do something to prepare for Shabbat, however important they are.
- Prepare on Friday if you can; in winter or if you work, Thursday is absolutely fine.
- Also do something for Shabbat shortly before it begins.
- If you find something special during the week and may not find it again, keep it for Shabbat.
- Stop regular work for yourself from minhah ketanah on Friday, unless it is occasional or for Shabbat needs.
- Employers must give Jewish employees enough time to get home and prepare.

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